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covers: "James 2:14-26. Filming reference, in delivery order. Part 2 of the chapter."

source: "Research and reading chain in [James 2 - Reading Plan and Video Mine](#).

Continues [James 2 - Filming Script](#) (2:1-13)."

James 2:14-26 — The Faith the Demons Have

Scripture from the NIV. Beats run in delivery order. Quotes in the shaded blocks are verbatim and can be read aloud as they stand. This picks up exactly where Part 1 left off, on the hinge in verse 13.

The passage

James 2:14-26

14 What good is it, my brothers and sisters, if someone claims to have faith but has no deeds? Can such faith save them? **15** Suppose a brother or a sister is without clothes and daily food. **16** If one of you says to them, "Go in peace; keep warm and well fed," but does nothing about their physical needs, what good is it? **17** In the same way, faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead.

18 But someone will say, "You have faith; I have deeds." Show me your faith without deeds, and I will show you my faith by my deeds. **19** You believe that there is one God. Good! Even the demons believe that—and shudder.

20 You foolish person, do you want evidence that faith without deeds is useless? **21** Was not our father Abraham considered righteous for what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? **22** You see that his faith and his actions were working together, and his faith was made complete by what he did. **23** And the scripture was fulfilled that says, "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness," and he was called God's friend. **24** You see that a person is considered righteous by what they do and not by faith alone.

25 In the same way, was not even Rahab the prostitute considered righteous for what she did when she gave lodging to the spies and sent them off in a different direction? **26** As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead.

Beat 1 — Same man, same clothes. The subject never changed.

Everyone reads this paragraph as a new topic. Faith and works. The big systematic fight. It is not a new topic. It is the second half of a sentence that started at the top of the chapter.

Verse 13 was the hinge, not the ending. "Mercy triumphs over judgment." And then, without a breath, verse 14: what good is faith with no deeds.

Then watch who walks back into the room in verse 15:

2:15-16. "Suppose a brother or a sister is **without clothes** and daily food. If one of you says to them, 'Go in peace; keep warm and well fed,' but does nothing about their physical needs, what good is it?"

Now go back thirteen verses, to the man James opened with:

2:2. "a poor man in **filthy old clothes** also comes in."

Same man. Same clothes.

The "deeds" in the famous faith-and-works argument are not abstract deeds. James defines them by pointing. They are what you failed to do for the guy you seated on the floor at the top of the chapter. He never changed the subject. The partiality passage and the faith passage are one argument, and verse 13 handed the baton from one to the other.

So before we say a single word about Paul, the framing is already wrong. This was never a treatise on faith and works in the abstract. It is a man finishing a point about a poor man in shabby clothes.

Beat 2 — "Works" is not Paul's word for works

The whole quarrel with Paul rests on one assumption: that James's **erga**, works, and Paul's "works of the law" are the same object. Read both in context and they are not.

Look at what James's works actually are, every time he gives an example:

- **2:15-16.** Feed the hungry. Clothe the naked.
- **2:25.** Rahab hides the spies, gives them lodging, sends them out safe.

Works of **mercy**. Toward a body. The exact list from **1:27**: look after orphans and widows in their distress. James's "works" are the corporal mercies, done to the person with no ring.

Now Paul's "works of the law," in the letters where he fights about them:

- **Galatians** and **Romans 3-4**. The works in dispute are **circumcision**, food laws, Sabbath, the calendar. The Torah boundary markers. The things that mark off a Jew from a Gentile.

Paul's question is: **what makes a Gentile a member of the people of God?** And his answer is, not the boundary markers, not the badge of Torah. James's question is: **is the faith you are claiming alive or dead?** Two different questions. Two different objects wearing the same English word.

You can show that from context alone. No systematic theology, no Trent, no Wittenberg. Just read what each man puts on the table when he says the word.

Beat 3 — The faith the demons have

Here is the sharpest verse in the passage, and almost nobody sits on it long enough:

2:19. "You believe that there is one God. Good! **Even the demons believe that—and shudder.**"

James reaches for the most perfect creed available to a Jew. "There is one God." That is the **Shema**, Deuteronomy 6:4, the line every faithful Israelite says twice a day. The bedrock of monotheism. James picks the single most correct sentence a person can believe.

And he hands it to demons.

The demons are orthodox. Their theology is flawless. They have the doctrine exactly right, more certainly than you do, and it produces **shuddering**, not communion. Perfect belief, zero relationship.

So watch what James has just done to the word faith. The "faith" he is attacking is **bare assent**. Knowing the proposition is true. Signing the statement. That kind of faith a demon has, and has better than you.

That is the faith that is "by itself." That is the dead one. And hold this, because it is the whole knot in the next beat: **that is not the faith Paul is talking about when Paul says a man is justified by faith.**

Beat 4 — "Faith alone" appears once in the Bible, and it is about the demons' faith

2:24. "You see that a person is considered righteous by what they do and **not by faith alone.**"

This is the verse. The one that supposedly detonates Paul. And here is a fact worth saying slowly on camera: **that phrase, "faith alone," appears exactly once in the whole Bible, and it is here, being negated.**

But look at which faith is being negated. The faith "alone" in verse 24 is the faith defined five verses earlier in verse 19. The demon's faith. Assent with no life in it.

Now put Paul's faith next to it. Paul's justifying faith, in his own words:

Galatians 5:6. "The only thing that counts is **faith expressing itself through love.**"

Paul's faith already has the works inside it. It is not assent, it is allegiance. Trust that acts. A living relation. Paul would agree, word for word, that assent-with-no-love justifies nobody. He says so himself.

So James and Paul are using the same spelling for two different things. James's "faith alone" is the demons' creed. Paul's "faith" is a trust that works through love. They are not contradicting. They are not even talking about the same interior act.

And that is the move this whole channel is built on. **Last episode, one Greek word hid the argument** — *prosōpolēmpsia*, face-receiving, and the entire passage turned on it. **This episode it is two words**, *pistis* and *erga*, faith and works, and Paul and James each fill them with a different life. A five-hundred-year war, and a large part of it was a collision of vocabulary. Two men said "faith" and meant two things, and the church split down the seam.

Beat 5 — Why Abraham and Rahab, of all people

James proves his point with two witnesses, and the pairing is the argument.

2:21. "Was not our father **Abraham** considered righteous for what he did..."

2:25. "was not even **Rahab the prostitute** considered righteous for what she did..."

Abraham and Rahab. Stop on that pair. It is not random and it is not two nice Bible stories.

Abraham is the founding **insider**. The patriarch. Father of the nation. The most respectable name a Jew can say.

Rahab is the total **outsider**. Foreign. A woman. A Canaanite. A prostitute. She has no lineage, no legal standing, no patron, no ring. In the language of last episode, she is a person with **no persona** — no face the world would receive.

And James sets them side by side and says both were **considered righteous for what they did**, in the same breath, with the same verdict.

Look at what he just did. In his own proof, James refuses to receive the face. He will not pick only the respectable example. He gives you the patriarch and the whore and prices them identically. **That is 2:1 performed** — do not judge by the face — done inside the argument that is supposed to be about something else. It was never about something else.

And Rahab's "work"? She hid the vulnerable and sent them out a different way. Hospitality to the stranger. Shelter for the hunted. Another corporal mercy, toward bodies in danger. The same works as verse 16, the same works as 1:27. The chapter has one subject from top to bottom, and the poor man, the orphan, the widow, the spies, and Rahab are all the same person: the one with no standing, met with mercy instead of a price.

Beat 6 — Same proof text, two moments in one life

This is where the Paul knot actually unties, and it is beautiful, so take it slow.

Both men quote the **same verse** to prove opposite-sounding points:

Genesis 15:6. "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness."

Paul quotes it in **Romans 4**. James quotes it in **2:23**. Same sentence. And here is the thing nobody points out: they are quoting it about **two different days in Abraham's life**.

Paul reads it at **Genesis 15** — the night God shows Abraham the stars and promises a son, and Abraham believes, and it is credited then and there. Before Isaac is born. Before circumcision. Paul's whole point in Romans 4 is the timing: the credit came first, on nothing but trust.

James reads it forward to **Genesis 22** — the binding of Isaac, the knife on the mountain, decades later. And listen to his verb:

2:22-23. "his faith was **made complete** by what he did. And the scripture was **fulfilled** that says, 'Abraham believed God...'"

Made complete. Fulfilled. James is not saying Abraham earned the verdict at Genesis 22. He is saying the sentence written at Genesis 15 came **true**, came to its completion, thirty years later on the mountain. The faith that was real in chapter 15 is the faith that walked up the hill in chapter 22. One faith. Proven alive by lasting that long and acting.

So Paul freezes the frame at the moment of the promise. James runs the tape forward three decades. **Neither is wrong about the reel**. Faith credited at 15. Faith made complete at 22. Not two verdicts fighting each other. One life, filmed at two moments, by two men who each needed a different frame.

Beat 7 — Dead faith is a corpse, not a weak faith

Now the word James actually uses, twice, for faith without works. Not "weak." Not "immature." Not "incomplete."

2:17. "faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is **dead**."

2:26. "As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is **dead**."

Nekra . A corpse. And the analogy in verse 26 is not moral, it is ontological. **As the body without the spirit is dead.** A dead faith is not a faith that is doing badly. It is a faith with the shape of the thing and none of the life. A body with no spirit is not a weak person. It is a corpse. It looks exactly like the living thing, and it is the opposite of it.

There is even a pun buried in verse 20. "Faith without deeds is **useless**," the NIV says. The Greek is **argē** — idle, barren — and it is literally **a-ergos** , *work-less*. Faith without **erga** is **a-erga** . Un-worked. James is saying the word has eaten itself.

Now pull last episode's deepest thread forward, because this is where it lands. Zizioulas said the works of love are not a payment laid on top of a nature. They are **what the new nature does natively**, the way exclusion is what the old nature does natively. And James already planted that in chapter 1:

1:18. "He **chose** to give us **birth** through the word of truth."

Chose, and birth. A new birth makes a new nature, and a nature **acts**. It cannot help acting, the way a living body cannot help breathing.

So put the two deaths together. **Faith without works is not an unpaid invoice**. It is a claimed birth with no family resemblance. A birth certificate and no living child. The demon in verse 19 is the proof of it: maximal correct belief, and no communion. The demon has the entire creed and none of the life, which is exactly a person collapsed into a thing that merely knows facts. Faith as data, against faith as communion.

And that is the answer to the whole faith-and-works war, and it was sitting in chapter 1 the entire time. Nobody was ever arguing about a ledger. Two men said the word faith and meant two lives, and one of those lives was already a corpse before the argument started.

The caveat, said plainly on camera

Three honest flags, because the channel runs on not overclaiming.

One. I am not saying Paul and James are identical twins with no difference of emphasis. They emphasize different things because they are fighting different fires. The claim is narrower and stronger than "they agree": they are answering **different questions with a shared vocabulary**, and the flat contradiction people quote — "faith alone" against "not by faith alone" — is a collision of terms, not of doctrines.

Two. Verse 24 does negate "faith alone," and I am not going to soften that to keep anybody comfortable. It says what it says. The entire point is what the word "faith" means when James says it, and verse 19 already told us: the faith James kills is the faith a demon has.

Three. The Zizioulas reading — nature, birth, the works as native act — is a **convergence**, not James's conscious intent, exactly like last time. James is not writing fourth-century theology. But the same shape shows up in his letter and in their creed, and that is worth the video.

The open loop into the next episode

Verse 26 leaves us on an image: **the body without the spirit**. A dead body. And then chapter 3 opens on a single organ of that body.

3:8. "the tongue... a restless evil, full of deadly poison. **With the tongue we praise our Lord and Father, and with it we curse human beings.**"

The same mouth doing two opposite things. Blessing and cursing out of one hole. Which is the divided man again — **dipsychos**, double-minded, from 1:8, the man who was the wave of the sea in 1:6 and the

split assembly in 2:4. The fracture we have been tracking the whole time, now moved into the mouth.

The body is dead in 2:26. In chapter 3 we find out which part killed it.

That is next time.